

VIVID EXPRESSIONS 'The Last Bite' by Krishen Khanna

One of the most erudite and creative of Indian artists, Krishen Khanna at the age of 99 is as animated and active as ever. He moves around, albeit in a wheelchair, and paints regularly. When asked how he feels at this stage of his life, he says he feels he is lucky that he doesn't have any illness. Barring a left hip replacement surgery that was performed this May after a fall, he seems to have no other problem. While this slowed him down a little, it also made him work in a concentrated manner.

If there is any regret at all, it is about the absence of his colleagues, most of whom are no longer alive. "I'm quite short of friends and I miss them. They all stayed with me in Shimla. Tyeb Mehta, Bal Chhabda...no one is there any longer." Khanna's meeting with M.F. Husain was especially important. The artist recalls Husain visiting him and how that left an indelible mark on him.

"When I came to Bombay, the Progressive Artists' Group (PAG) was already there.... Then I ran into Husain and I remember he came to see me in my little room at Chateau Windsor—which was next to the Ambassador Hotel. I had a room right on top and he borrowed a book from me—Clive Bell's *Art*. And then he lost that in a taxi. He brought a painting as compensation and left a little note with it. The painting was worth vastly in excess of the price of the book," Khanna says. "We became good friends and the fervour with which he painted added fuel to the sparks which had already ignited in me.... I saw almost every painting he made and over the next few years, I bought several. His prices were modest. One day I was driving home through the crowded Princess Street. Just as I passed Chemould Frames, my eye was

A HOMECOMING OF SORTS

Indian contemporary artist Subodh Gupta's exhibition **The Way Home** ***pays homage to Bihar, where his roots lie***

Artist Subodh Gupta's upcoming solo exhibition, *The Way Home,* is special in many ways. It's the first time his artworks will be shown in his home state Bihar, which has played muse many times over his two-decade-long career. "In 1999, I made an artwork, 'The Way Home', which isn't a part of my current exhibit. But I liked the name so much that I decided to use it again. It was the first utensil work I displayed in any gallery, which has now become my identity," he shares.

The show's name, Gupta says, is to depict the dichotomy of Bihar that is much talked about in political and social circles. "Bihar is a cultural state and has a rich history. At the same time, contemporary Bihar is complex; it was also termed the 'Wild West of India'," he adds. "Through these works, I wanted to present the state through a lens where religion, animal and society co-exist."

The Way Home, supported by Nature Morte, will display 20 of Gupta's works at Patna's Bihar Museum between November 9, 2024, and February 15, 2025. The retrospective has been curated by Anjani Kumar, director general of the Bihar Museum.

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"I trained as a painter and eventually started doing sculptures. You will see both in my show. My earliest work, part of *The Way Home*, is a self-portrait titled 'Bihari' that I made in 1999 while living in Delhi," he recalls. "When I moved to the national capital, I observed the